



EUROPEAN COMMISSION 2026

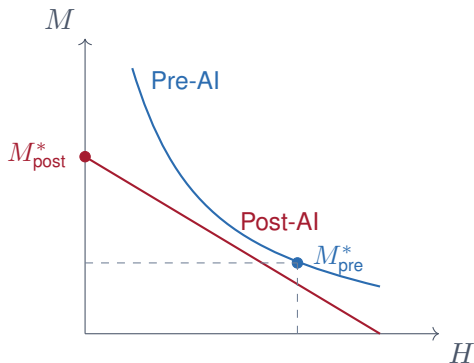
Claude Code for Empirical Research

Agents, workflows, and difference-in-differences

Scott Cunningham · Baylor University

European Commission · June 3–4, 2026

AI flattens the isoquants of cognitive production



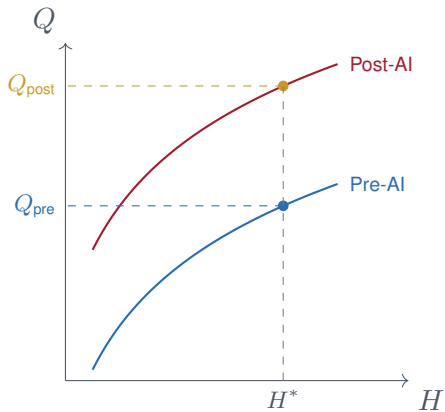
$$Q = f(H, M)$$

- H = human time and attention
- M = machine time

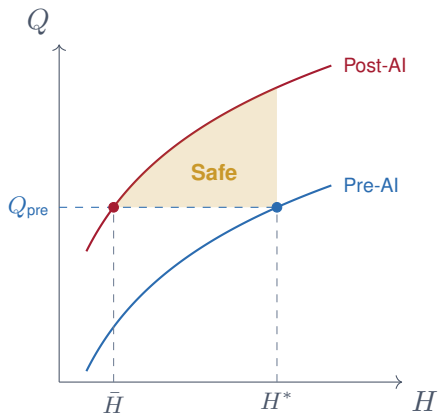
The question isn't whether to use M .

It's how much H you keep.

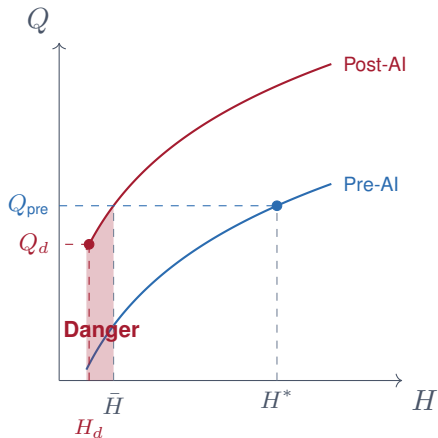
AI shifts the production curve up



Safe: take time back, stay above $\bar{H}$



Danger: $H < \bar{H}$, skills depreciate



Three kinds of AI assistance

Chatbot You ask. It answers. Conversation ends.

Copilot Sits alongside your work. Suggests completions.

Agent Wrapped in a loop. Uses tools. Iterates. Plans.

Today: agents.

Download Claude Code from the official source only

`claude.com/download`

Start with the **desktop app** — no terminal required to begin.

Available for macOS and Windows.

A new phishing attack: fake install sites

Fake “Claude Code install” pages are circulating. They ask you to copy and paste a command into your terminal. That command installs malware.

- The threat won't come through email
- It looks like a legitimate software install page
- **Never paste terminal commands from a website you didn't navigate to yourself**

Source: TechRepublic (2026) · `claude.com/download` is the only safe path.

MixtapeTools: skills for empirical research

`github.com/scunning1975/MixtapeTools`

A library of Claude Code skills built for researchers.

`/newproject` `/split-pdf` `/referee2`
`/beautiful_deck` `/blindspot` `/compiledeck`

/newproject: scaffold a project in seconds

```
/newproject
```

Creates:

- Standard directory structure (data/, code/, output/, docs/)
- CLAUDE.md with project context
- README.md

Give Claude access to your folder and a chapter from the Mixtape as context.

Starting a zero-shot now — in the background

One prompt. No instructions. Just a research question.

Objective: develop a DiD study using Italian or European data.

Binary treatment. Staggered adoption.

CS estimator.

We'll come back to this at the end of the day and see what was produced.

AER is already seeing the wave

Friend 1 · 10:17 PM

“Just learn that AER is already seeing a big inflow of AI papers lol”

“Written by AI. They are very concerned.”

“No way they can handle 20–50% more papers”

“12 editors each handling 200 papers right now”

Friend 2 · 10:18 PM

“Haha written by AI or about AI?”

“\$1,000 submission fee!”

This conversation happened
this week.

Zurich Social Catalyst Lab: papers from the workshop

After the Zurich workshop (May 2026):

Participants built working papers using Claude Code and the methods from the course.

Zero-shot papers are not the ceiling. They are the floor.

We'll do this together — live

One DiD paper, built in plan mode, using CS.

Italian or European data. Staggered adoption. We know the estimator.

It will run **all day**.

We'll come back at the end and see where it is.

The workflow: nine steps in plan mode

1. **Choose covariates** via interview process
2. **Check balance** with balance tables
3. **Build propensity score**
4. **Visualize rollout** with `panelview`
5. **Rollout graphic** with cohort counts and sample shares
6. **Outcome by cohort** over time
7. **Choose target parameter** (weighted ATT)
8. **Estimate** simple average + event studies with CS
9. **Sensitivity analysis** with Rambachan–Roth

Verification: the human stays in the loop

/referee2	Results in a second language / framework
GTD harness	Organize and track multi-step pipelines
/beautiful_deck	Compile results into a presentation

The agent does the work. You verify the design and the findings.

The agent does the work.

You set the question.

You verify the design.

You own the answer.
